Blend of colour and art

At a low table, two artists bend over their panels of cloth, pen in hand. In the twinkling of an eye, with no prior tracing or sketch, miraculously materialise, or so it seems to the bemused observer figures of dancing peacocks, their magnificient plumage spread out in a glorious fan of intricate designs, surrounded by tendrils and flowers. A perfectly proportioned figure of Lord Ganesha on another panel is soon followed by similar mythological figures, each distinctive in its own way. The "kalam" or brush wielded magically by the artists is what gives this hoary craft its name — "Kalamkari". With its roots in antiquity (with samples discovered from Egyptian burial grounds in the 10th and 11th centuries) these exquisitely painted pieces embody the dedication and skill of the Indian craftsmen at his best and it is in Sri Kalahasti in Andhra Pradesh that the art now survives in its pure and pristine form.

The exhibition of Kalamkari paintings of Sri Kalahasti at Sakshi Gallery, (from December 17-20, 10 a.m. to 7 p.m.) organised by the Crafts Council of India and the Office of the Development Commissioner (Handicrafts) bring the beautiful legacy of this finely developed and laboriously worked craft into our midst in a profusion of wall hangings, spreads and cushion covers.

Worked in muted browns and rusts, a magnificent huge piece on Lord Venkateswara with softly worked panels on all sides stands testimony to the aesthetic and artistic skills of the craftsmen. Glowing as a deep set garnet set in pearls, the piece is as ageless and splendid as the art itself. Blended with the Indian artistry are to be seen touches of the Persian influence during the medieval period Kalamkari pieces were much sought after by Persian merchants though Persia of itself was a centre of the craft. Trade links between Safavid Persia and Qutbshahi Golconda gave a boost to the Kalamkar art on the south-east coastline of India.

But it is mythology which form the main inspiration of Kalamkari artists whose works were meant primarily for religious use — as backdrops and hangings in temples and places of worship.

An important feature of Kalamkari is that following age-old traditional methods, only vegetable dyes are used. These are extracted from barks, flowers, seeds and leaves and the process of painting is an elaborate one requiring 17 stages or more with the cloth being washed at every stage. Soaking the cloth in buffalo milk and using dung for bleaching are effective time-tested methods which are still being adhered to. The history of vegetable dyeing in India harks back to the days of the Indus Valley Civilisation as the discovery of a piece of madder-dyed fabric at Harappa proves. It was to Indian vegetable-dyed fabrics that the West turned, to adorn themselves and their homes for centuries.

Though the product is of lasting beauty and worth and the craft a finely evolved one, the marketing of these fabrics needs greater guidance and encouragement according to Mr. M. V. Narayana Rao, Director (Southern Region), Office of the Development Commissioner (Handicrafts) Southern Region. The Andhra Pradesh State Government runs a training centre for the artists. Since indigo dyeing had been discontinued some 50 years ago, recently a workshop to revive the art of indigo dyeing was conducted at Sri Kalahasti. Efforts are also on to help designers tour the area and offer valuable suggestions and guidance to the artists and to make the art more relevant to everyday use by adapting designs to cushion covers, pillow slips, etc.

Mrs. M. Sheela Priya, Director, South Zone Cultural Centre (Thanjavur) who inaugurated the exhibition stressed the need to create awareness about the high quality of our dying crafts and to help the craftsmen.

Demonstrations by national award winning craftsmen — Messrs. J. Gurappa Chetty and K. Ramaniah also form part of the exhibition.

The Hindu/18-12-1987/3